

High-chance portions — hist-medieval

Combined original study articles for this topic's highest-probability PYQ themes.

Bhakti & Sufi Movements: Saints, Ideas, Social Impact

~36% · Bhakti saints & teachings · Sufi orders · Social impact

Nirguna–Saguna saints and Sufi silsilas — devotion, social critique and culture overlap.

Why UPSC asks this

High overlap with culture and society; personality–teaching matching is MCQ-friendly.

Bhakti spectrum

Bhakti traditions emphasised personal devotion over pure ritual brokerage. Nirguna streams (Kabir, Nanak) stressed formless divine and social critique of caste hypocrisy; Saguna streams (Tulsidas, Mirabai, Chaitanya) centred on Rama/Krishna devotion with regional literatures. Basavanna and Virashaiva movements in Karnataka, Warkari saints in Maharashtra, and Alvars/Nayanars in the Tamil bhakti deep past all feed matching questions.

Sufi silsilas

Sufi orders adapted Islamic mysticism to Indian social landscapes. Chishti openness to local cultural forms (Ajmer's Khwaja Muinuddin) contrasts with more court-leaning Suhrawardi patterns in textbook contrasts. Khanqahs, langars, and music (sama) appear in culture–society questions. Avoid crude “Sufi = syncretic always” absolutism; study order-by-order.

Why UPSC asks

Saints produce clean option rows; social impact statements test whether you overclaim egalitarianism. Tie architecture (dargahs) and literature (vernacular) to Art & Culture.

Must remember

- Kabir, Nanak, Basavanna, Chaitanya, Mirabai, Tulsidas — map idea to saint
- Chishti (Ajmer) vs Suhrawardi accents
- Nirguna vs Saguna devotion

Delhi Sultanate & Mughal Administration

~34% · Iqta & market reforms · Mansabdari/Zabti · Mughal institutions

Iqta, market control, Mansabdari and Zabti — institutions over battle lists.

Why UPSC asks this

Institutional continuity/change questions dominate medieval polity PYQs.

Sultanate institutional core

Focus on iqta as a revenue–service mechanism, nobility factions, and Alauddin Khalji's market regulations (grain prices, checks on hoarding) as classic Prelims fodder. Tughlaq experiments (token currency, capital shifts) are cautionary “innovation risk” tales — know outcomes at headline level.

Mughal administrative grammar

Mansabdari ranked nobles (zat/sawar); jagirdari linked salary claims to revenue assignments; Zabti measurement–assessment traditions associated with Todar Mal. Akbar's sulh-i-kul and religious discussions at Ibadat Khana appear in culture–polity crossovers. Decline narratives should stress jagir crisis and regional assertiveness rather than only “weak later kings”.

Architecture bridge

Indo-Islamic arches, domes, gardens and city building (Fatehpur Sikri, Shahjahanabad) overlap culture-arch questions — keep dynasty! “monument pairs tight.

Must remember

- Alauddin Khalji — market/price control experiments
- Iqta — revenue–military assignment logic
- Mansabdari zat/sawar; Zabti/Todar Mal bandobast